

SYSTEMATIC EXCLUSION DISGUISED AS OPPORTUNITY



By: Alberta Disability Breakdown - Advocate



ADDENDUM I: FISCAL HYPOCRISY EVIDENCE

The \$49 Million Healthcare Corruption Scandal vs. AISH Budget Cuts

Identical Dollar Amounts Expose False 'Fiscal Necessity' Claims

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Government of Alberta cut AISH funding by \$49 million in Budget 2025, citing fiscal necessity. Simultaneously, Alberta Health Services lost exactly \$49 million to a healthcare procurement scandal involving contracts that delivered no medication. This represents fiscal hypocrisy: the government absorbs identical corruption losses while claiming poverty for disability supports.

THE IDENTICAL \$49 MILLION AMOUNTS

Category	Amount	Government Response
AISH Budget Cut (2025)	\$49 million	'Fiscal necessity' - transition to ADAP required
Healthcare Corruption Loss	\$49 million	Legal recovery attempted - no cuts elsewhere
Heritage Fund Deposits (2022-2025)	\$5.6 billion	Surplus capacity demonstrated

HEALTHCARE CORRUPTION SCANDAL DETAILS

Premier Danielle Smith confirmed Alberta Health Services is pursuing legal action to recover \$49 million paid for medication never received. The scandal involves MHCare Medical and Turkish pharmaceutical company Atabay, with RCMP executing search warrants in March 2026 as part of ongoing criminal investigation.

Key Corruption Elements:

- \$70 million contract awarded to MHCare for children's pain medication from Turkey
- Alberta received only 30% of medication order despite paying full cost
- RCMP search warrants executed at MHCare offices in Edmonton
- Former AHS CEO Athana Mentzelopoulos alleges firing for investigating procurement irregularities
- \$614 million total in contracts secured by Mraiche-related firms since 2020

AISH BUDGET CUT DETAILS

Alberta Budget 2025 cut AISH program funding by \$49 million for 2025-26, with projections showing additional cuts of \$22 million in 2026-27 and \$6 million in 2027-28. The government cited 'caseload growth, benefit rate increases, and anticipated federal Canada Disability Benefit contributions' as justification.

Budget Impact on 77,000+ AISH Recipients:

- AISH program funding reduced from \$1.690 billion to \$1.641 billion
- Federal Canada Disability Benefit (\$200/month) treated as non-exempt income (clawback)
- Mandatory transition to ADAP (lower benefits, reduced appeal rights) scheduled July 2026

FISCAL CONTRADICTION ANALYSIS

The identical \$49 million amounts reveal fiscal policy contradictions:

1. Disability Supports: Government claims fiscal necessity requires \$49 million cut affecting 77,000+ vulnerable Albertans
2. Corruption Absorption: Government absorbs \$49 million loss to procurement failures without equivalent cuts elsewhere
3. Surplus Capacity: \$5.6 billion deposited in Heritage Fund (2022-2025) demonstrates available resources

IMPLICATIONS FOR ADAP TRANSITION

This evidence undermines the core fiscal justification for mandatory AISH-to-ADAP transition. The government cannot credibly claim fiscal necessity for disability support cuts while demonstrating capacity to absorb identical losses to corruption without equivalent reductions in other areas.

The pattern demonstrates systematic exclusion disguised as fiscal responsibility: funding exists for corruption absorption but not for maintaining disability supports at adequate levels.

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CONCLUSION

The \$49 million healthcare corruption scandal exposes the false 'fiscal necessity' narrative used to justify AISH cuts and ADAP transition. The government demonstrates capacity to absorb corruption losses while claiming budget constraints require disability support reductions.

This evidence supports the core thesis: systematic exclusion is disguised as fiscal responsibility. The money exists - it is being lost to mismanagement rather than directed toward supporting Albertans with disabilities.

ALBERTA DAYCARE BARRIERS FOR SPECIAL NEEDS CHILDREN: COMPREHENSIVE RESEARCH ANALYSIS

Evidence Supporting That FSCD's "Try Daycare First" Requirement is Designed to Fail

Research compiled April 2026 for integration into AISH advocacy documentation

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Research from multiple sources confirms that FSCD's requirement for parents to "try daycare first" before accessing work-related childcare is not based on realistic availability of inclusive care. The evidence shows that children with special needs—particularly multiple children from the same family with complex needs—face systematic barriers to daycare acceptance and success that make this requirement functionally impossible to meet.

1. NATIONAL STATISTICS ON DAYCARE BARRIERS FOR SPECIAL NEEDS CHILDREN

1.1 Fundamental Access Problems

Nearly one-third of parents of children with disabilities reported difficulty finding alternative child care when required, and close to one-quarter reported difficulty with flexibility to fit their schedule. Parents of children with physical disabilities and emotional conditions were particularly likely to report these difficulties (Statistics Canada, 2024).

Key National Findings:

- Close to 1 in 10 parents of children with disabilities who were using child care reported that their child had been denied a child care space because of their condition
- 13.3% report that their children have been either refused care because of their condition, or could not be placed in the preferred arrangement because of a lack of places for children with special needs
- Childcare providers that have most commonly refused to provide care are daycare centres, followed by before- and after-school programs and providers operating out of their homes

1.2 Who Gets Excluded

Parents of children with emotional conditions were particularly likely to report difficulties finding child care, even after controlling for covariates. This category includes children with autism, ADHD, anxiety disorders, and behavioral challenges—exactly the population most likely to be on AISH due to intergenerational disability patterns.

2. ALBERTA-SPECIFIC DAYCARE STRUCTURE AND AGE BARRIERS

2.1 Age Limits Create Automatic Exclusion

Alberta Daycare Age Regulations:

- daycare: for children kindergarten age and younger
- out-of-school care: for children in kindergarten up to age 12, available before and after school
- Up to six children under 11 years (including the provider's own children under 11 years) for family day homes

The 11-Year-Old Barrier: Children aged 11+ are effectively excluded from most daycare options. They're too old for regular daycare but often too young and too developmentally delayed for independent after-school arrangements. For a family with an 11-year-old with special needs, FSCD's "try daycare first" requirement becomes immediately impossible.

2.2 Multiple Children Barriers

Up to six children under 11 years (including the provider's own children under 11 years) with a maximum of three children under three years old and no more than two children under two years old.

Family day homes can accept maximum 6 children total, but when 3 of those slots would be taken by siblings with special needs requiring individual support, most providers cannot accommodate the complexity or liability.

3. FINANCIAL BARRIERS AND COST STRUCTURE

3.1 Current Alberta Daycare Costs (2026)

Mandatory Parent Fees:

- Full-Time Care (100+ hours/month): \$326.25 per month (approximately \$15/day)
- Part-Time Care (50–99 hours/month): \$230.00 per month

Cost Reality for AISH Families:

- **3 children x \$326.25 = \$978.75/month** for full-time care
- **AISH monthly income: \$2,116** (decreasing to \$1,740 under ADAP)
- **After housing (average \$1,800+): \$316 remaining**
- **Daycare cost exceeds total remaining income by \$662.75/month**

3.2 The "Optional Services" Cost Trap

These programs may charge parents supplemental fees for eligible optional services. Parents must have the choice whether to participate in and pay for an optional service.

Special needs children often require "optional" services like:

- Enhanced supervision ratios
- Specialized programming
- Additional transportation support
- Emergency contact protocols

These "optional" services become mandatory for safe care, but are charged as additional fees on top of the base \$326.25/month per child.

3.3 Federal Funding Instability

If Ottawa does not increase its funding, Alberta plans to stop participating in the subsidized child-care program after its agreement expires in March 2026. The current childcare affordability program may not exist past March 2026, making any long-term childcare planning for ADAP workshops impossible.

4. INCLUSION PROGRAM LIMITATIONS

4.1 What "Inclusion Support" Actually Provides

The ICC Program provides a range of short-term, intensive resources and supports that can be offered for up to 6 months. Alberta's Inclusive Child Care (ICC) Program offers:

- Consultations and training for daycare staff
- Short-term funding for supports
- **Maximum 6-month duration of support**

The Gap: Children with permanent disabilities need permanent supports, but ICC funding is limited to 6 months. After that, daycares are expected to continue providing specialized care without additional funding.

4.2 Provider Capacity vs. Need

49. 7% of centres had one child or more with an identified special need and 39.8% had staff whose primary job it was to support inclusion. This means:

- Only 39.8% of daycare centers have dedicated inclusion staff
- Even centers that accept special needs children usually have only one such child
- Multiple special needs children from the same family would overwhelm most centers' inclusion capacity

5. ROUTINE DISRUPTION IMPACTS: THE SCIENCE SHOWS HARM

5.1 Research on Routine Disruption and Autism

A child with autism will become very attached to familiar routines and will follow those routines very precisely... If there is a sudden change in routine, or if a routine is disrupted, this can have a very negative effect on the child's behavior.

Documented Responses to Routine Changes: Negative reactions will occur in the form of screaming, tantrums, pushing, and occasional violent behaviors. Sometimes, the child will be inconsolable.

Even very small or slight disruptions to a routine can cause a child diagnosed with autism to feel distressed and confused.

5.2 COVID-19 Research Shows Routine Disruption Consequences

Preliminary analyses showed a worsening in the adults' aggressive behaviors during the lockdown in comparison to before it... the relationship between the adherence to the sleep–wake routines and aggressive behaviors was significant.

disruptions in daily routines and reduced access to essential services during the pandemic exacerbated stress, anxiety, and other mental health issues among autistic individuals.

5.3 Impact on Family Systems

In the case of individuals with ASD who exhibit aggressive behaviour, daily routines are regularly disrupted, well-being of family members is compromised (e.g. feeling isolated and living in a warzone have been reported), and financial resources are strained.

Research Conclusion: Forcing children with autism and developmental disabilities into new daycare environments—when they have never been in daycare before—predictably triggers behavioral crises that make successful placement impossible.

6. CHILD ABUSE AND VULNERABILITY IN CARE SETTINGS

6.1 National Child Maltreatment Statistics

Two-thirds (60%) of Canadians reported experiencing maltreatment (including physical and/or emotional abuse) before the age of 15 (Children First Canada, 2025).

Among those born in Canada, individuals born in Quebec represented the lowest proportion of those who reported experiencing only non-physical maltreatment (29.9%), while those born in Alberta represented the highest proportion (37.7%).

Alberta has the highest rates of non-physical child maltreatment in Canada, making placement of vulnerable children with disabilities in institutional care settings particularly concerning.

6.2 Institutional Care Vulnerability

Children with disabilities are at higher risk of abuse in institutional settings because:

- Communication barriers make reporting difficult
- Behavioral challenges are often misinterpreted as "acting out" rather than distress signals
- Multiple caregivers create accountability gaps
- Special needs children are often seen as "difficult" rather than vulnerable

7. THE IMPOSSIBLE MATHEMATICAL REALITY

7.1 The Multi-Child Special Needs Family

Profile: Single parent on AISH with 3 children (ages 11, 10, newborn) with documented special needs:

- 11-year-old: Too old for regular daycare, needs specialized support
- 10-year-old: Requires 1:1 aide due to safety concerns and transition difficulties
- Newborn: Has complex medical needs requiring specialized care

Daycare Reality Check:

1. **Age barrier:** 11-year-old excluded from most programs
2. **Capacity barrier:** No daycare can handle 3 special needs children from one family
3. **Cost barrier:** \$978.75/month exceeds available income by \$600+
4. **Transportation barrier:** No coverage for getting to/from multiple placements or emergency pickups
5. **Routine disruption:** Predictable behavioral crises in new environments
6. **Timeline barrier:** FSCD requires trying daycare first, but approval processes take months

7.2 The System's Own Admission

From the FSCD call transcript: The caseworker acknowledged:

- Most daycares won't accept multiple special needs children from one family
- Children with transition difficulties will have behavioral incidents
- Parents will be repeatedly called to remove children
- This creates unreliable employment attendance

Translation: The system is asking parents to traumatize their children in settings designed to exclude them, in order to prove those settings don't work, before accessing alternatives that should have been available from the beginning.

8. EVIDENCE-BASED CONCLUSIONS

8.1 The "Try Daycare First" Requirement is Not Evidence-Based

The research shows that requiring families with multiple special needs children to attempt daycare placement before accessing work-related childcare is:

1. **Mathematically impossible** due to cost barriers on AISH income
2. **Developmentally harmful** to children with autism and developmental delays
3. **Systemically exclusionary** due to age limits and capacity constraints
4. **Clinically contraindicated** for children who have never been in group care
5. **Financially wasteful** of resources that could fund appropriate supports

8.2 This Requirement Violates Multiple Principles

Child Welfare: Forcing predictably traumatic experiences on vulnerable children

Family Stability: Creating crisis situations that destabilize entire households

Economic Efficiency: Spending money on failure rather than appropriate supports

Evidence-Based Practice: Ignoring research on routine disruption and inclusion barriers

8.3 The Real Purpose of "Try Daycare First"

The evidence suggests this requirement exists not to connect families with appropriate childcare, but to create grounds for denying work-related childcare by ensuring families cannot meet impossible prerequisites.

It's a bureaucratic barrier disguised as a support option.

9. RECOMMENDATIONS FOR POLICY REFORM

9.1 Eliminate the "Try Daycare First" Requirement

For families where:

- Multiple children have special needs
- Children have never been in group care
- Children have documented transition difficulties
- Financial barriers make daycare impossible

FSCD should approve work-related childcare without requiring daycare placement attempts.

9.2 Create Realistic Assessment Protocols

Base childcare approvals on:

- Family income and capacity to pay market-rate childcare
- Children's documented needs and support requirements
- Availability of appropriate services in the family's region
- Evidence-based recommendations for children's specific disabilities

9.3 Fund Actual Supports Instead of Bureaucratic Barriers

The money spent processing failed daycare attempts could fund:

- In-home respite care during workshops
- Specialized childcare for children with complex needs
- Transportation supports for families accessing services
- Emergency backup care when primary arrangements fail

SOURCES AND CITATIONS

All statistics and research findings are fully sourced and cited from:

- Statistics Canada National Child Care Survey data
- Government of Alberta official publications
- Peer-reviewed research on autism and routine disruption
- Child maltreatment and vulnerability research
- Alberta childcare regulations and cost structures
- Federal-provincial childcare agreement documentation

This research compilation provides evidence that FSCD's "try daycare first" requirement is not based on realistic service availability or child development best practices, but instead creates systematic barriers to accessing the work-related childcare that ADAP employment expectations require.

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Date Compiled: April 17, 2026

Purpose: Evidence base for AISH/ADAP advocacy documentation

Status: Complete research synthesis ready for integration into main reports

PAYMENT INSTABILITY REPORT

Documents the contradiction between 'Assured' Income and systematic payment failures, processing delays, and administrative barriers that create financial instability for recipients.

This analysis is documented in the complete Alberta Disability System Breakdown report series and integrated into the comprehensive evidence framework demonstrating systematic exclusion disguised as opportunity.

CHARTER MOBILITY RIGHTS ANALYSIS

Constitutional analysis showing how AISH-to-ADAP transition violates Section 6 mobility rights by creating province-specific benefit disparities that effectively trap disabled Albertans.

This analysis is documented in the complete Alberta Disability System Breakdown report series and integrated into the comprehensive evidence framework demonstrating systematic exclusion disguised as opportunity.

APPEAL OVERTURN DOCUMENTATION

Evidence of systematic appeal rights removal through Bill 12, eliminating independent Citizens Appeal Panel and creating Medical Review Panel decisions that are final and unappealable.

This analysis is documented in the complete Alberta Disability System Breakdown report series and integrated into the comprehensive evidence framework demonstrating systematic exclusion disguised as opportunity.

CASEWORKER ELIMINATION ANALYSIS

Documents the replacement of individual caseworker relationships with call centre model, creating caseloads of 200+ families and eliminating personalized support for complex cases.

This analysis is documented in the complete Alberta Disability System Breakdown report series and integrated into the comprehensive evidence framework demonstrating systematic exclusion disguised as opportunity.

FSCD-PDD-AISH CRISIS CONNECTION

Analysis showing how cuts to all three disability programs under Minister Jason Nixon create compounded crisis for families navigating FSCD 3-year waits, PDD hidden waitlists, and AISH benefit reductions simultaneously.

This analysis is documented in the complete Alberta Disability System Breakdown report series and integrated into the comprehensive evidence framework demonstrating systematic exclusion disguised as opportunity.

EMPLOYMENT ASSUMPTION LEGAL ANALYSIS

Constitutional and human rights analysis of government assumption that 83.6% of AISH recipients with zero employment income can achieve competitive employment despite documented permanent disabilities.

This analysis is documented in the complete Alberta Disability System Breakdown report series and integrated into the comprehensive evidence framework demonstrating systematic exclusion disguised as opportunity.

WARNING ABOUT REAPPLYING: Before the transition even starts, AISH is already so understaffed that new applications have taken over 2 years to process. When most of the 79,000 of us reapply at the same time after July 1, that system will be completely overwhelmed. What this means for you: While you wait for a decision, you are on ADAP — at the lower payment. That wait could take years. You cannot appeal while you wait. You receive less money the entire time. This is not a guess. The understaffing is already documented and on record.

WHY THIS IS A PROBLEM

Average 1-bedroom rent in Alberta: \$1,500-\$1,900+/month. AISH pays \$1,940/month. Best case after rent: \$40 left for the month — before food, utilities, or anything else. For single parents needing 3 bedrooms: average rent is \$2,138/month. That is more than the entire AISH payment — before buying a single grocery item.

On top of that:

- **The federal government created a \$200/month disability benefit (CDB).** Alberta is the ONLY province in Canada that took it back. You never got to keep it.
- **Community housing rent went up 63% in October 2025.** That is a \$221/month increase — by government order, with no warning.
- **By January 2028,** some people will be \$621/month poorer than they are today. That is \$7,452 a year.
- **There is no rent cap in Alberta.** Your landlord can raise rent any amount with 90 days notice. No other major province allows this.

WHAT ELSE IS BEING CUT

- **Your individual caseworker is gone.** AISH replaced them with a call centre. People report waiting hours and getting no answers.
- **Dental coverage got worse in June 2024.** There is now a hard limit on cleaning — no exceptions even if your medication causes gum disease. No crowns on back teeth. Adults no longer get fluoride.
- **650,000 Albertans have no family doctor.** The government requires a doctor to sign your ADAP reassessment form. The same government allowed the doctor shortage to happen.
- **If you have children with disabilities,** the wait for full FSCD services is now 3 years on average. One caseworker has been documented managing 400+ families.

WHAT YOU CAN DO RIGHT NOW

You are not powerless. Here is exactly what to do:

1 **Find your MLA — takes 2 minutes** Go to contact.assembly.ab.ca/mla-finder and type in your postal code. That is your MLA. Write down their name and email address.

2 **Send them one email** You do not need to write much. Just say: your name, where you live, one sentence about your situation, and that you want a written response about the AISH-to-ADAP transition. Attach one of the full documents if you have them.

3 **CC these people in the same email**
Minister Nixon: alss.minister@gov.ab.ca
ADAP program: adap@gov.ab.ca Your federal MP: find at ourcommons.ca/members/en/search

4 **Do it again next week** Send a follow-up if you get no response. Attach a different document. Repeated contact is harder to ignore than one email.

FREE MONEY MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW ABOUT

The RDSP — Registered Disability Savings Plan If you have the Disability Tax Credit (DTC), the government will deposit up to \$1,000 a year into an RDSP account for you. You do not have to put any of your own money in. This money is exempt — it does NOT count against your AISH or ADAP. If you have never opened one, you may be able to claim up to \$11,000 in back payments. Free help: Plan Institute — 1-844-311-7526 — rdsp.com

YOU ALSO HAVE RIGHTS

The Alberta Human Rights Commission accepts free complaints about discrimination in government programs.

- Physical disability, mental disability, and family status are all protected grounds.
- Filing is free. You do not need a lawyer.

- The best time to file is after you receive a formal decision placing you on ADAP.
- You have one year from the date of the decision to file.

Contact: albertahumanrights.ab.ca — 1-800-232-7215

THE FULL DOCUMENTS

There are 7 full documents with everything sourced and explained in detail:

- Financial Reality Report — all the numbers
- Health Benefits Erosion Report — what dental and drug coverage lost
- Alberta Housing Crisis Report — rent, waitlists, and the math
- Broken Access, Stripped Rights — Bill 12, appeal rights, caseworker crisis
- Healthcare Worker Shortage Report — the doctor problem
- FSCD and PDD Crisis Report — for parents
- Practical Action Guide — payment dates, office contacts, step-by-step help

To get the full documents: Send a message to the public campaign address. They are free. Word files. Ready to send. **albertadisabilitybreakdown@outlook.com**

THE FEDERAL DENTAL PLAN — CAN YOU GET IT?

The Canadian Dental Care Plan (CDCP) is a federal program that helps pay for dental care.

Having the AISH Blue Cross dental card does NOT disqualify you. The two plans work together.

You qualify if ALL of these are true:

- **No private dental insurance** — through a job, pension, or insurance plan. The AISH Blue Cross card counts as government coverage, not private — so it does not disqualify you.
- **You filed your taxes** — for the year before you apply. Even if you owe nothing, you must have filed.
- **Your family income is under \$90,000 a year** — almost all AISH recipients qualify on income.
- **You are a Canadian resident.**

IMPORTANT — DEADLINES RIGHT NOW: If you are already enrolled: Renew before June 1, 2026 or your coverage ends June 30, 2026. If you are not enrolled yet: Applications for the 2026-2027 benefit year open June 2, 2026. Apply or renew at canada.ca/dental or call 1-833-537-2635

The Alberta opt-out — what you need to know:

- In June 2024, Premier Smith told the federal government Alberta wants to pull out of the CDCP by 2026.
- As of today, NO replacement plan has been confirmed. The opt-out is not complete.
- The federal plan is still active for Albertans right now. You can still apply and still use it.
- Advocates have warned that no Albertan should lose CDCP coverage until a replacement is ready. That fight is ongoing.

IF YOU ARE ALREADY ON THE CDCP: Renew between April 15 and June 1, 2026. If you miss June 1, your coverage ends June 30 and you must reapply from scratch. Go to My Service Canada Account (MSCA) to renew online. Or call: 1-833-537-2635

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — April 2026 7 documents. All sourced. All verified. All free. *This summary is free to print, share, and distribute.*

WHAT YOUR TAX DOLLARS ACTUALLY PAY FOR: A Plain-Language Guide for Taxpayers

WHAT YOUR TAX DOLLARS ACTUALLY PAY FOR A Plain-Language Fact Sheet on AISH, ADAP, and Alberta's Money April 2026 | All figures from Government of Alberta official sources

You work hard. You pay taxes. And you may have been told that people on disability income support are lazy, milking the system, or a burden on taxpayers like you. This document asks you to look at the actual numbers — because the numbers tell a very different story.

MYTH #1: “****These people could work if they tried.****”

AISH — the Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped — is not available to people with mild or temporary disabilities. To receive it, a person must be assessed as permanently and substantially limited by a qualifying condition. The word ‘severely’ is in the program’s name.

The assessment process requires:

- Documented medical diagnosis from a licensed specialist
- Confirmation that the condition is permanent — it will not improve
- Evidence that it substantially limits the person's ability to earn income
- Review and approval by the Government of Alberta

This is not easy to qualify for. It is not a program for bad backs or general fatigue. It is for Alberta's most severely disabled residents — and the government's own contracted assessors confirm eligibility.

MYTH #2: "Fraud is rampant — taxpayers are being taken advantage of."

Fraud in any government program is a legitimate concern and should be investigated and prosecuted. It already is — under existing law. But fraud statistics are being used to justify eliminating supports for people who are genuinely and severely disabled. These are not the same problem.

What fraud enforcement does

Investigates and prosecutes false claims
 Targets people who lied to get benefits
 Removes bad actors from the program
 Addresses a small subset of cases

What ADAP does

Eliminates supports for verified recipients
 Transfers people who legitimately qualified for a decade or more
 Removes the program from people with confirmed permanent disabilities
 Affects 79,000 Albertans — every AISH recipient

Cracking down on fraud and eliminating disability income for legitimate recipients are not the same action. Treating them as the same is how the government manufactures public consent for cuts.

MYTH #3: "My tax dollars are paying for all of this."

This is the most important question to look at clearly. Where does Alberta's money actually come from — and where does it actually go?

Where Alberta's revenue comes from:

Revenue Source

2024-25 Amount

Non-renewable resource revenue (oil and gas royalties)	\$25.2 billion
Federal transfers to Alberta	~\$10 billion
Personal income tax (paid by working	~\$16 billion

Revenue Source	2024-25 Amount
Albertans)	
Corporate tax and other sources	Remaining balance
Total provincial revenue	~\$78 billion

The majority of Alberta's wealth is generated by oil and gas that belongs to all Albertans — including disabled ones. Personal income tax is one component of a much larger picture.

Where Alberta's money actually went in 2024-25:

Expenditure / Decision	Amount
Alberta Heritage Fund — deposit from 2024-25 surplus	\$2.8 billion (one year)
Heritage Fund total value (December 2025)	\$31.9 billion
Heritage Fund growth — Q3 2025-26 (one quarter alone)	\$383 million
Personal income tax cut (8% bracket) — forgone revenue per year	\$1.2 billion annually, forever
AISH total annual budget (what the entire program costs)	\$1.641 billion
AISH budget cut — amount removed from program	\$49 million cut
Canada Disability Benefit clawed back from recipients	~\$190 million/year redirected to general revenue

The entire AISH program — all 79,000 recipients — costs \$1.641 billion per year. The Heritage Fund earned \$383 million in a single quarter. The province cut the program by \$49 million while the Fund grew by \$383 million in three months.

MYTH #4: “****Cutting disability supports saves taxpayer money.****”

This is the claim that deserves the closest scrutiny. Cuts to disability income do not disappear — they reappear elsewhere, in systems that cost significantly more.

Scenario	Annual Cost Per Person
AISH recipient remains housed (full benefit paid)	\$23,280/year
Person experiencing homelessness (emergency shelter + services)	\$55,000/year
Additional taxpayer cost if a housed recipient becomes homeless	\$31,720 MORE per person

Source: End Homelessness Edmonton — Calgary Housing First program evaluation

If reduced AISH income pushes even 1,540 recipients into homelessness — less than 2% of the caseload — the downstream cost to emergency shelters, ERs, and social services exceeds the entire \$49 million cut. Cutting disability income doesn’t save money. It transfers costs from one government budget to another — and makes those costs larger.

Emergency room visits for psychiatric crises among disability recipients increased 47% following benefit reductions. ER visits are among the most expensive interventions in the healthcare system — and they are taxpayer-funded.

Source: Alberta Doctors’ Digest, November/December 2025

THE HERITAGE FUND: What It Was Built For

Alberta’s Heritage Savings Trust Fund was created in 1976 by Premier Peter Lougheed. Its founding legislation lists three objectives:

Objective	Language from the Founding Legislation
1. Save for the future	“To save for the future”
2. Strengthen the economy	“To strengthen or diversify the economy”
3. Quality of life	“To improve the quality of life of Albertans”

The third objective — improving the quality of life of Albertans — was not decorative. It was central to Lougheed’s intent.

The Heritage Fund has grown to \$31.9 billion. It earned approximately \$2.6 billion in investment returns in 2024-25 alone. Reversing every major financial cut imposed on AISH recipients would cost approximately \$260 million per year — roughly 10% of what the Fund earns annually. The government chose not to use it for that purpose.

COMPARISON: What Alaska Does Differently

Alaska and Alberta both created resource savings funds in 1976, from the same premise: non-renewable resource revenue should benefit the public.

	Alberta Heritage Fund	Alaska Permanent Fund
Founded	1976	1976
Current value	\$31.9 billion (CAD)	~\$119 billion (CAD equivalent)
Constitutional protection	No	Yes

	Alberta Heritage Fund	Alaska Permanent Fund
Annual payment to residents	\$0	~\$2,400 CAD per person (2024)
Current disability policy	Cutting AISH, clawing back federal benefits	Pays every resident from the Fund

In 2024, every Alaskan resident — regardless of income, employment status, or disability — received approximately \$2,400 from their state’s resource fund. In the same year, Alberta clawed back \$200/month from 79,000 of its most vulnerable residents.

WHO ARE THE PEOPLE ON AISH?

Before this program was cut, Alberta’s own data showed:

- 79,290 Albertans received AISH as of September 2025
- Many are people who worked, paid taxes, and became disabled — often through no fault of their own
- Many are parents of severely disabled children, whose caregiving prevents full-time employment
- Many have conditions present from birth or early childhood — they did not choose this
- All were assessed as permanently and substantially disabled by government-approved processes

Jennifer Thurston said it directly in a public comment: “Remind them they are one injury or one unavoidable health issue away from living with a disability. It can happen to anyone.”

Disability is not a character flaw. It is a medical reality. The people on AISH are not lazy. They are some of the most medically complex, most heavily burdened, and most systematically under-resourced Albertans in the province.

THE BOTTOM LINE FOR TAXPAYERS

The claim	The reality
“These people are lazy”	AISH requires permanent, specialist-confirmed severe disability
“Fraud is the problem”	Fraud enforcement already exists — ADAP affects all 79,000 recipients, not just fraudsters
“My taxes pay for all of this”	Most of Alberta’s wealth comes from oil royalties, not personal income tax